

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Corporate Strategy English

Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For corporate strategy, CEO office, transformation, corporate development, strategic finance, product strategy, and internal consulting teams.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

Activity system

Reinforcing set of activities that makes a strategy harder to copy.

Adjacency

Growth area near the core by customer, channel, capability, geography, or value chain.

Ambition

High-level performance or market position the company wants to achieve.

Barrier to entry

Structural obstacle that limits new competitors.

Big bet

Large commitment that could create major upside or major loss depending on future conditions.

Board narrative

Concise strategy story for oversight, alignment, and decision-making.

Build-buy-partner

Comparison of internal development, acquisition, and partnership routes.

Capital allocation

Decision process for assigning capital to businesses, initiatives, acquisitions, or returns.

Core business

Current business central to revenue, profit, capabilities, or strategic identity.

DCF

Discounted cash flow valuation based on expected future cash flows.

Decision rights

Clarity on who recommends, decides, executes, and escalates.

Diagnosis

Explanation of the strategic problem, its cause, and why it matters now.

Divestiture

Sale, exit, or separation of a business, asset, or product line.

EBITDA

Earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation, and amortization.

Five Forces

Framework for industry structure: entrants, suppliers, buyers, substitutes, and rivalry.

Governance cadence

Regular rhythm for decision, review, escalation, and accountability.

Horizon one

Current core businesses that deliver most present profit and cash flow.

Horizon three

Earlier options, pilots, or ventures that could create future growth.

Horizon two

Emerging opportunities that may become significant future businesses.

Inorganic growth

Growth through acquisition, merger, joint venture, or investment.

Issue tree

Structured breakdown of a problem into analyzable questions.

KPI

Key performance indicator tied to a strategic objective or decision.

Margin expansion

Improvement in profitability as a share of revenue.

Market entry

Plan to enter a new geography, segment, category, or value-chain position.

No-regrets move

Action likely to create value across multiple plausible futures.

North Star

Single guiding objective or metric that aligns strategic direction.

NPV

Net present value; value of future cash flows after discounting and subtracting investment.

OKR

Objectives and key results; goal-setting system linking outcomes to measurable progress.

Operating model

How structure, roles, processes, governance, incentives, and capabilities support strategy.

Opportunity cost

Value sacrificed by keeping scarce resources in a lower-priority use.

Organic growth

Growth generated from existing business activities, customers, products, or channels.

PMI

Post-merger integration; work required to combine and realize value after a deal.

Profit pool

Where profit accumulates across segments, value chain positions, or business models.

Residual uncertainty

Uncertainty remaining after strong analysis has been completed.

Resilience

Ability of the strategy and organization to absorb shocks and keep creating value.

Right to play

Credible permission or relevance to compete in a market.

Right to win

Credible basis for outperforming alternatives in that market.

Risk appetite

Amount and type of risk leadership is willing to accept to pursue value.

Roadmap

Sequenced plan of initiatives, milestones, dependencies, and owners.

ROIC

Return on invested capital; profit relative to capital invested in the business.

SAM

Serviceable available market; portion the company can realistically reach with its offer and model.

Scenario planning

Structured analysis of plausible futures and their implications for decisions.

Sensitivity

Analysis showing how results change when key assumptions change.

SOM

Serviceable obtainable market; share the company can reasonably capture.

Strategic choice

Decision about where to focus, how to win, what to build, and what not to do.

Strategic option

Limited investment that preserves future ability to scale, pivot, or exit.

Strategic thesis

Argument for why a course of action should create advantage or value.

Substitute

Different product or service that meets the same underlying need.

Synergy

Incremental value from combining businesses, assets, capabilities, customers, or costs.

TAM

Total addressable market; full demand opportunity if all relevant customers were served.

Tradeoff

A deliberate decision to deprioritize one attractive option to make another choice coherent.

Transformation office

Team coordinating large-scale strategic change and value delivery.

Trigger indicator

Signal that shows which scenario may be unfolding and when to revisit a decision.

Value driver

Factor that materially affects enterprise value, such as growth, margin, capital intensity, or risk.

WACC

Weighted average cost of capital; benchmark return required by capital providers.

White space

Underserved market, customer need, or value-chain position where the company may compete.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Ask a precise question

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Explain a fair comparison

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Match certainty to evidence

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Make a complex point clear

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Offer a workable tradeoff

We can ..., provided that

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

Help a group reach a clear next step

Let's hear ... before we decide.

The point we still need to resolve is

Who will make this decision, and what do they need?

Summarize the issue neutrally, invite missing perspectives, and distinguish discussion from decision. State who can decide and record any unresolved question. Do not assume silence means agreement.

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Strategy Role, Problem Framing, and Executive Diagnosis

An executive asks for a "growth strategy" but has not specified whether the priority is revenue, profit, or market entry.

Which outcome are we trying to improve, over what period? Revenue growth, profit improvement, and entry into a new market may require different choices. Let's define the decision first.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

02 | Strategic Choices: Ambition, Where to Play, How to Win, and Tradeoffs

A team can invest in its core service or enter a new segment. The same staff would support both, and capacity is limited.

The two options compete for the same team. Expanding the core uses existing capabilities; entering the segment requires new ones. We should make the resource tradeoff explicit before selecting a direction.

Try it again: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

03 | Industry Structure, Competitive Dynamics, and Profit Pools

A market estimate is based on total industry spending, but the company can serve only one customer segment.

Total industry spending is broader than our addressable opportunity. I'll separate the overall market from the segment we can serve and explain the assumptions used to estimate our potential share.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

04 | Business Models, Unit Economics, Capabilities, and Advantage

A new service has positive revenue growth but negative contribution after variable delivery costs. A slide calls growth proof of a sound business model.

Growth shows demand, but it does not by itself demonstrate attractive unit economics. Let's explain the revenue and variable costs per unit before drawing conclusions about the model.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

05 | Portfolio Strategy, Capital Allocation, and Resource Reallocation

Two divisions request the same investment budget. Neither proposal explains what work would stop if it were funded.

Could each division identify the expected benefit, key assumption, and activity it would deprioritize? That would let us compare the proposals as allocation choices rather than separate wish lists.

Try it again: The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

06 | Growth Strategy, Market Entry, Partnerships, and M&A Logic

An acquisition proposal lists possible cost savings. No integration plan or implementation estimate has been prepared.

These are potential synergies, not confirmed savings. I'll distinguish the opportunity from the work and cost required to achieve it so the proposal presents a balanced strategic case.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

07 | Uncertainty, Scenarios, Strategic Options, and Risk Posture

A planning workshop has a base case and a downside case. The team wants to call one a prediction.

These scenarios explore different conditions; neither is a promise about the future. Let's identify the signals we would monitor and which decisions we would revisit if conditions changed.

Try it again: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

08 | Execution Governance, Operating Model, KPIs, and Board Narrative

A board presentation has twelve metrics but no clear request. The sponsor needs approval for a limited pilot.

The decision today is whether to authorize the pilot. I'll lead with that request, the proposed scope, and the measures for reviewing it, then use the remaining metrics as supporting detail.

Try it again: A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-06. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Build vocabulary and collocations

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Corporate Strategy English

Professional audience: corporate strategy, CEO office, transformation, corporate development, strategic finance, product strategy, and internal consulting teams

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Strategy Role, Problem Framing, and Executive Diagnosis

Original fictional case: An executive asks for a "growth strategy" but has not specified whether the priority is revenue, profit, or market entry.

Language workshop: Ask a precise question

Communication goal: Clarify missing information before responding.

Language guidance: Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): When you say ..., do you mean ...? / Could you clarify which ...? / So, my understanding is Is that right?

Vocabulary: Diagnosis: Explanation of the strategic problem, its cause, and why it matters now. / Ambition: High-level performance or market position the company wants to achieve. / Strategic thesis: Argument for why a course of action should create advantage or value. / Issue tree: Structured breakdown of a problem into analyzable questions.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Which outcome are we trying to improve, over what period? Revenue growth, profit improvement, and entry into a new market may require different choices. Let's define the decision first.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Vocabulary in use

1. Choose four useful terms from the reference. For each, give a plain-English meaning in this field, two natural word combinations (collocations), one realistic example and a likely misuse or contrast. Keep the examples consistent with the reference and avoid jargon that does not fit this occupation.
2. Add four related terms that would be useful in a different common situation in the same field. Label these as suggested extensions, explain how they connect to the work, and flag regional or organizational variation where relevant. Do not pad the list with synonyms nobody would use at work.
3. Start a retrieval round: give one short workplace sentence with a gap and a clear clue. Ask me to supply the best term and explain my choice. Stop and wait; do not reveal the answer or a completed sentence yet. Accept another term if its meaning and collocation work.
4. After my attempt, explain one useful distinction and ask me to write my own sentence. Wait, correct a genuine meaning or usage problem, then give the next retrieval question. Work through four questions one at a time.
5. Finish with a short handoff or message task using three terms, followed by two recall questions I can save for another day. Do not pretend to schedule a reminder.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Test recall and transfer

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

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Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

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END REFERENCE

TASK: A short retrieval session

1. Tell me to close my notes. Plan six questions: two vocabulary-in-context items, one grammar or meaning contrast, one question about a confirmed versus unknown detail, one short spoken-style response and one new-situation transfer task. Use the supplied material as the answer reference, but do not repeat its existing checks word for word.
2. Ask only the first question, then stop and wait. Prefer a short answer over a multiple-choice question. Do not display the remaining questions, model answers or a word bank in advance.
3. After each answer, say what it gets right and explain a meaningful error if there is one. Accept alternative wording when it preserves the facts and does the communication job. If I struggle, give one clue and invite a retry before revealing a model. Only then move to the next question.
4. Keep a simple record of which items I answered independently, with a hint, or after seeing a model. This records today's practice, not a certified proficiency score. Do not judge pronunciation from typed text.
5. At the end, summarize two strengths and two useful next steps with examples from my answers. Give me a small review card containing three prompts and a separate answer section. Suggest that I revisit it tomorrow and a week later; do not claim you will remember this session or send reminders. Label the final transfer scenario as fictional.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level